

networks and deepen the roots.

Over the last few decades, the Government has steadily evolved from taking an overly interventionist role to a more supportive role in the area of business. This supportive role needs to be further refined and enlarged in the area of infrastructure, which holds the key to our economic productivity. Innovative PPP models, once again should show us the way forward, given the Government's resource constraints and execution capabilities in this regard. The spirit of a supportive Government also needs to cascade down the bureaucratic

the wheel of growth. Sustained and coordinated action both from the Government as well as the industry can help us tap this hitherto untapped energy. The success of the thousands at the top should not distract us from the potential of the millions at the bottom.

The challenge today clearly lies in building a competitive and innovative economy. "Being connected," I believe, is an essential precondition for building such an economy. From a dairy farmer or a vegetable producer in the countryside to the big corporations in the metros, everyone's productivity seems anchored to this essential condition. We need a powerful thrust to create broadband connectivity in the country.

Globalisation is an essential condition for global leadership. The current crisis need not be a deterrent on this score. India's remarkable resilience in the face of the crisis only reiterates the validity of our calibrated globalisation efforts. India should be bold to raise the limits and open more sectors for Foreign Direct Investment (FDI). I believe the economy is in the right hands that we can trust to set the way forward.

In a globalised world, markets have no boundaries. Indian corporate leaders will ac-

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levels below, which will increase the ease of doing business. This is particularly important for the large number of small and tiny businesses across the country.

Sustained efforts from successive governments have served to clear the large cobwebs of the licence raj. However, remnants of the outdated structure still remain. The new round of reforms, such as the introduction of a unified tax structure like the GST, will go a long way toward cleaning up the way ahead.

A "receding" Government participation has signalled a freeing of the entrepreneurial energy in the economy. The phenomenal corporate growth over the past decade bears clear testimony to this but to me this at best reflects our success at the top of the pyramid. There still exists a huge mass of self-employed/entrepreneurs at the bottom. The improved productivity of this large mass would surely spur growth in the economy. They constitute a critical cog in

cordingly have to alter the competitive framework they envision themselves to be engaged in. Many of them have, of course, already been doing so. The spate of successful global mergers and acquisitions undertaken during the last few years clearly highlights both intent and ability on this front. Some of the acquisitions made in buoyant times at higher valuations may have dampened a few hearts temporarily when the global slowdown approached. I firmly believe these blips will be no deterrent in the long term. As Indian businesses mature further in their respective domains, we are likely to witness more such deals.

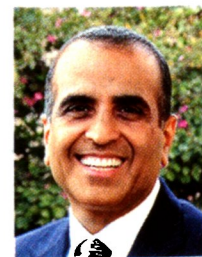
We are truly living through a historic period on the civilisational time scale, when the contours of the global power balance are set to be realigned. To go back to Hugo's famous words, I clearly see the idea on the horizon. As a nation, we have to stand up and take destiny in our hands and make it happen. ■

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India today is poised to shape the emerging world order. This has to be done by gaining economic strength, technological vitality and quality moral leadership.”

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